

Aalok Varma

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CURRENT POSITION

Postdoctoral Fellow, Laboratory of Dr Loren Looger
University of California, San Diego

Sep 2023–Present

EDUCATION

PhD Neuroscience, Laboratory of Dr Vatsala Thirumalai
National Centre for Biological Sciences (Tata Institute of Fundamental Research), Bangalore

Aug 2015–Aug 2023

BSc Biotechnology
School of Life Sciences, Manipal University, Manipal

Aug 2012–Aug 2015

PUBLICATIONS

Primary Research

- Jambor H, Antonietti A, ..., **Varma A**, ..., Weissgerber T. [Creating clear and informative image-based figures for scientific publications](#). *PLoS Biology* (2021)
- Varma A**, Udupa S, Sengupta M, Ghosh P, Thirumalai V. [A machine-learning tool to identify bistable state from calcium imaging data](#). *Journal of Physiology* (2024)
- Narayanan S, **Varma A**, Thirumalai V. [Predictive neural computations in the cerebellum contribute to motor planning and faster behavioral responses in larval zebrafish](#). *Science Advances* (2024)
- Agarwal V, Narayanan S, Sengupta M, **Varma A**, Sarkar S, Chinta S, Thirumalai V. [Highly synchronized inhibition from Purkinje cells entrains cerebellar output in zebrafish](#). *bioRxiv* (2024)
- Dalmeida R, **Varma A**, Anil A, Palakodeti D, Gulyani A. [Temporal integration and active sensing of light in planarians](#). *bioRxiv* (2025)

Advocacy and Science Citizenship

- Varma A**. [Peer Review: Feeling like a 'real' scientist](#). *eLife* (2022)
- Kent. BA, Holman C, ..., **Varma A**, ..., Weissgerber T. [Recommendations for empowering early career researchers to improve research culture and practice](#). *PLoS Biology* (2022)
- Urban L, ... **Varma A**, ... [Point of View: eLife's new model and its impact on science communication](#). *eLife* (2022)

HONORS AND AWARDS

Whitman Fellowship, Marine Biological Laboratory (MBL), Woods Hole, MA	Jun 2026–Aug 2026
Torrey Pines Training Consortium (TPTC) Postdoc PITCH – Second Place and People's Choice Award	Oct 2025
UCSD Postdoc PITCH – First Place	Apr 2025
Hello Bio Lab Hero Award – Runner-up	Dec 2024
Kavli-Grass Fellowship, Marine Biological Laboratory (MBL), Woods Hole, MA	May 2024–Aug 2024
Society for Neuroscience (SfN) Trainee Professional Development Award (TPDA)	Nov 2023
Carl Storm International Diversity Fellowship, Gordon Research Conference	Jul 2022
CTEP Travel Award, Department of Biotechnology of India (DBT)	Jul 2022
Infosys Leading Edge Travel Award	Jul 2022
International Brain Research Organization (IBRO) Travel Award	Jun 2017
Infosys Travel Award	Jun 2017
Dr TMA Pai Gold Medal, Manipal University	Nov 2015

WORKSHOPS/CONFERENCES ATTENDED

Selected Talk: <i>Cephalopod Neuroscience Gordon Research Conference</i>	Feb 2026
Participant: <i>Society for Neuroscience (SfN) Annual Meeting</i>	Nov 2025
Participant: <i>Bridging Biomedical Breakthroughs Summit, UC San Diego</i>	Nov 2025
Participant: <i>UC San Diego Gene Therapy Initiative Symposium: Vector Optimization</i>	Jun 2025

Invited Session Chair: <i>Allen Institute/Kavli Foundation Neurobiology in Changing Environments Symposium</i>	Apr 2025
Selected Talk: <i>Janelia Conference on Genetic Tools for New Model Organisms</i>	Mar 2025
Participant: <i>Cephalopod Neuroscience Conference and Workshop</i>	Apr 2024
Poster Presenter: <i>Society for Neuroscience (SfN) Annual Meeting</i>	Nov 2023
Selected “Spotlight” Talk: <i>ICTP-ICTS Winter School on Quantitative Systems Biology: Machine Learning in Biology</i>	Dec 2022
Poster Presenter: <i>Gordon Research Conference (GRC) in Molecular and Cellular Neuroscience</i>	Jul 2022
Poster Presenter: <i>Society for Neuroscience (SfN) Annual Meeting</i>	Nov 2021
Invited Talk: <i>25th Latin American Congress for Microbiology</i>	Aug 2021
Selected Talk: <i>No Garlands Neuroscience (NGN) Conference, Indian Institute of Science Education and Research (IISER, Pune)</i>	Jan 2020
Selected Participant: <i>Cold Spring Harbor Labs (CSHL) Ion Channels in Synaptic and Neural Circuit Physiology Course</i>	Jun 2017
Selected Participant: <i>Sixth Annual Science Journalism Workshop, NCBS</i>	Jun 2016
Selected Participant: <i>Lecture Series in Advanced Biology: Disease Biology, NCBS, Bangalore</i>	Jan 2015-Mar 2015

LEADERSHIP AND SERVICE

Ad-hoc Reviewer: <i>Journal of Experimental Biology (JEB), Homeworld Collective Garden Grants</i>	2025
Moderator: <i>Undergraduate Summer Research Program, UC San Diego</i>	Aug 2025
Postdoc Representative: <i>Search Committee for Dean of Graduate Education and Postdoctoral Affairs, UC San Diego</i>	Jun 2025
Member and Co-Chair: <i>Early Career Advisory Group (ECAG), eLife</i>	May 2021–Oct 2023
Documentation Team Lead: <i>NCBS/inStem COVID-19 Testing Centre</i>	May 2020–Aug 2020
Community Ambassador: <i>eLife Community Ambassador Program</i>	Apr 2019–Apr 2020

TEACHING, MENTORSHIP, AND OUTREACH

Public Lecture: <i>Suds & Science, Fleet Science Center</i>	Mar 2026
Guest Lecture: <i>BILD 62: Intro to Python for Biologists, UC San Diego</i>	Mar 2026
Volunteer and Event Lead: <i>Taste of Science, San Diego Chapter</i>	2025–Present
Mentor: <i>Biology Undergraduate and Masters Mentorship Program (BUMMP), UC San Diego</i>	Oct 2023–Oct 2025
Project TA: <i>Neuromatch Academy Computational Neuroscience Summer Course</i>	Jul 2023, Jul 2022
Coordinator and Instructor: <i>Lecture Series in Advanced Biology: Feedback Systems in Biology, NCBS, Bangalore</i>	Jul 2022
Co-organizer and Presenter: <i>Sympotein, NCBS, Bangalore</i>	2015–2018
Organizer: <i>Ideas without Borders, NCBS, Bangalore</i>	2015

LANGUAGES

English	Native
Malayalam	Native
Hindi	Native
Kannada	Fluent
French	Fluent (C2)
Spanish	Intermediate (B1/B2)
Japanese	Beginner (N5)

PROGRAMMING LANGUAGES

Python
MATLAB

Last updated: Thursday, March 12, 2026